



Verb

What is a Verb?

A verb is a word that is used to tell something about a person or a thing as follows

- (a) What a person or a thing does
(i) She teaches in our school. *(Active)*
(ii) He often visited his village. *(Passive)*
- (b) What is done to a person or a thing.
(i) He was punished. *(Passive)*
(ii) Shikha was taught a lesson. *(Active)*
- (c) What a person or a thing is
(i) She is a pretty village girl. *(Be' as a regular/ordinary verb)*
(ii) My brother is a Chemist.

There are two classes of verbs

- (A) The auxiliary verbs
- (B) The ordinary/regular verbs

(A) The auxiliary verbs are of two types

I. Primary auxiliaries

- (i) To be is, are, am, was, were, been, being.
- (ii) To have has, have, had.
- (iii) To do do, does, did.

II. Modal auxiliaries will, must, should, may etc.

(B) The ordinary verbs

to work, to play, to write.

The Use of 'To Be'

(1) As an auxiliary verb.

- (i) She is writing a letter. *(Active)*
- (ii) Arjun was called back. *(Passive)*

(2) As an ordinary/regular verb.

- (i) She is a doctor.
- (ii) She was present.

(For further details look up the chapter on Voice.)

Kinds of Verbs

1. Finite verbs

2. Non-finite verbs

1. **Finite Verbs** Finite verb has a subject of its own and is limited by the person and the number of the subject. *For example*

(i) She is **playing** Tennis.

(ii) They were **watching** television.

(a) **Transitive Verbs** Transit means 'to move'. The action of transitive verbs passes over to the object. *For example*

(i) She **writes** a letter.

(ii) She **teaches** me.

(b) **Intransitive Verbs** The action of the intransitive verbs does not pass over to the object. It goes back to the subject. *For example*

(i) She **cried** a lot.

(ii) She **came** on time.

NOTE Transitive verbs alone can be used in passive voice.

2. **Non-finite Verbs** Non-finite verbs are not limited by the person and the number of any subject. They are used without mentioning any subject.

Non-finite verbs are of three kinds.

(a) Infinitive

(b) Gerund

(c) Participle

For example

(i) She comes here to **study**.

(ii) We saw them **waiting** for the bus.

(iii) She likes **reciting** poems.

Rules of Verbs

Rule I

When two or more subjects are joined by 'as well as, like, unlike, besides, in addition to, with, together with, along with, and not, rather than, no less than, except, nothing but, more (men) than one', the verb is used according to the first subject. *For example*

(i) The director as well as the dancers were honoured by the public.

(Use 'was' in place of 'were')

(ii) The mother, and not her children have been arrested for committing theft.

(Use 'has' in place of 'have')

(iii) More men than one were absent yesterday.

(Correct)

(iv) Nothing but truth is immortal.

(Correct)

(v) My mother no less than my father is strict.

(Correct)

Rule II

When two or more subjects are connected by 'not only-but also, neither-nor, either-or, none-but' the verb is according to the nearest subject. *For example*

(i) Neither the students nor their guide were found present in the common room.
(Use 'was' in place of 'were').

- (ii) None but the leaders of our country is responsible for this state of affairs.
(Use 'are' in place of 'is')
(Correct)
- (iii) One or two books are needed.
(Correct)
- (iv) I or he is to be rewarded.
(Correct)
- (v) Am I or he to be rewarded?
(Correct)

Rule III

- (a) 'Neither, either, none, anyone, each, every' used as pronoun or adjective should be followed by third person singular verbs. *For example*
- (i) Neither of the two boys have done it.
(Use 'has' in place of 'have')
(Correct)
- (ii) Each of the students are obedient.
(Use 'is' in place of 'are')
(Correct)
- (iii) Either of us has done his work.
(Correct)
- (iv) Every boy and every girl has been invited.
(Correct)
- (b) When **None** is used with countable nouns both singular and plural verbs are correct. But with uncountable noun singular verb is correct.
- (i) None of the boys has/have done home work.
(Correct)
- (ii) None of the work is completed.
(Correct)
- (c) When 'each' is used after subject the verb is plural. *For example*
- (i) We each have taken our bags.
(Correct)
- (ii) They each are honest.
(Correct)

Rule IV

When plural nouns explain specific 'amount, sum, distance, quantity, time, period' as a whole the verb should be singular. *For example*

- (i) Four miles are not a long distance.
(Use 'is' in place of 'are')
(Correct)
- (ii) Two hundred rupees were a large amount fifty years ago.
(Use 'was' in place of 'were').
(Correct)
- (iii) Two hundred rupees were lost.
(Correct)

Rule V

The expression 'many a/an, more than one' should be followed by a singular noun and singular verb. *For example*

- (i) Many accidents have recently taken place.
(Correct)
- (ii) Many an accidents have recently taken place.
(The correct usage is 'many an accident has')
(Correct)
- (iii) More than one man was absent.
(Correct)
- (iv) More men than one were burnt.
(Correct. Refer to Rule I)

Rule VI

In a **compound sentence** both auxiliary verbs and principal verbs should be mentioned separately if they differ in **number, form or voice**. In such cases one verb cannot act for both the clauses. *For example*

- (i) He has not and will not marry in near future.
(Place 'married' after 'has not')
(Correct)
- (ii) She is intelligent but her sisters dull.
(Place 'are' after 'sisters')
(Correct)

- (iii) He surrendered before the court and sent to jail. (Use 'was' before 'sent')
- (iv) She disappeared last month and found dead near a well last night. (Place 'was' after 'and')
- (v) She is intelligent but her sister dull. (Correct)
- (vi) I did not and will not go there. (Correct)

Rule VII

The inverted form of the verb is used in the following cases

- (A) When the sentence is introduced by adverb.
 (B) When the verb is meant to express a wish or prayer.

For example

- (i) So quickly did she finish her work that we were surprised. (Correct)
- (ii) May you succeed in life. (Correct)
- (iii) Hardly/scarcely had I reached the airport when the plane arrived. (Correct)
- (iv) No sooner did she arrive than she started laughing. (Correct)

Rule VIII

The verb in the following cases is used in singular form.

- (A) When two singular nouns refer to the same person denoted by one article.
 (B) In certain phrases or idiomatic pair of words suggesting the same meaning, though not synonyms. *For example*
- (i) The Collector and District Magistrate are on a visit to the Tehsil today. (Use 'is' in place of 'are') (Correct)
- (ii) What is the aim and object of his costly plan? (Correct)
- (iii) The sum and substance of the passage is given below. (Correct)
- (iv) Bread and butter are sold here. (Correct)
- (v) Bread and butter is difficult to earn. (Correct)
- (vi) Two and two is/are four. (makes four) (Correct)
- (vii) No student and no teacher was present. (Correct)
- (viii) Three fives are fifteen. (Correct)
- (ix) Five times ten is fifty. (Correct)
- (x) Slow and steady wins the race. (Correct)
- (xi) Time and tide wait for none. (Correct)

Rule IX

- (a) **When the sentence begins with 'It'** the verb is according to the subject 'It'.
- (b) **In the case of a sentence beginning with 'there' and Interrogative pronoun,** the verb is according to the predicate/complement.
 However verb should not be used according to complement in other than these cases. *For example*
- (i) It is the stars that guide our destiny. (Correct)
- (ii) It is I who am helping you. (Correct)
- (iii) There was a boy in the classroom. (Correct)

- (iv) There were a boy and a teacher in the classroom. (Correct)
 (v) There lives a boy who is my best friend. (Correct)
 (vi) What evidence are these acts? (Correct)
 (vii) What have the boys thought about this plan? (Correct)

Rule X

(A) A singular or a plural verb with the nouns in the following cases is used according to the sense which they convey.

- (a) **Number**
 (c) Variety, plenty, rest, deal of, a lot of (lots of), a heap of, two thirds of, most of, some of, a half of, per cent of.
- (b) **Means, Wages**
 1. A large number of boys were absent on account of bad weather. (Correct)
 2. The number of admissions have gradually fallen off. (Use 'has')
- (b) **Means, Wages**
 3. She could not continue her study because her means were poor. (Correct)
 4. A fair means is always preferable to the foul one. (Correct)
 5. Means are more important than the ends. (Correct)
 6. The wages in India are quite meagre. (Correct)
 7. "Wages of sin is death", says the Bible. (Correct)

(c) Variety, Plenty etc.

8. A variety of books on the subject are available in the market. (Correct)
 9. A variety of food is available in this hotel. (Correct)
 10. Plenty of milk is available in this part of the country. (Correct)
 11. Plenty of books were donated to the library by him. (Correct)
 12. The rest of the lesson has been completed. (Correct)
 13. The rest of the students have left for their homes. (Correct)
 14. A lot of (lots of) guests were attended upon by the host. (Correct)
 15. A lot of work is yet to be done. (Correct)
 16. A great deal of labour is required to complete the job. (Correct)
 17. A good deal of boys have joined our club. (Correct)
 18. Two thirds of the actors are unsuccessful. (Correct)
 19. Two thirds of the book is easy to read. (Correct)
 20. The seventy per cent of the students are hard working. (Correct)
 21. The seventy per cent of our population is poor. (Correct)

NOTE (a) But with 'percentage' in the subject the verb is singular. For example

The percentage of successful candidates is very high.

- (b) A singular verb is used with collective nouns when they denote unity/a group.

"A set of books, a pair of spectacles, a bouquet of flowers, a kind of.

A series of events, A gang of robbers" etc. For example

- (i) A pair of spectacles is broken. (Correct)
 (ii) A series of matches is likely to be played next month. (Correct)

Rule XI Unreal Past/Subjunctive Mood

A wish, a regret, unlikely condition and contrary to fact statements are expressed in subjunctive mood.

(A) In subjunctive mood (present situation) we may use 'was/were', though 'were' is more correct form. (Simple past plural)

(a) **To express regret/wish for a present situation.** (at the time of speaking)

(i) I wish I had a house of my own now = I am sorry I don't have a house.

(ii) I wish I were rich now = I am sorry I am not rich.

I wish = would that, I would, If only.

(b) **To express unlikely condition.** *For example*

(i) If I had a house, I would not hire yours.

(ii) If I were a teacher, I would help you.

(c) **'As if/as though'**

The subjunctive can be used in a clause beginning with 'as if/as though' to express a statement contrary to the fact. *For example*
She behaves as if she were the landlady.

(B) After **'It is high time'** *For example*

It is high time you did something now.

(*In the sense of 'should'*)

(C) After **'would rather/had rather' + Clause**

These phrases are followed by a clause in a subjunctive mood. Otherwise direct infinitive is used. *For example*

(i) I would rather you helped my brother.

(ii) I had rather you stayed with me.

(iii) I would rather go to Mumbai.

(*Say 'would stay'*)

(*Direct Infinitive*)

(D) In subjunctive mood referring to Past situation use Past Perfect Tense.

For example

(i) I wish I had had a gun then.

(ii) I wish I had a gun now.

(iii) I wish I had not met her last year.

(*Past situation*)

(*Present situation*)

(*Regret for a past situation*)

Rule XII

The use of causative verbs. (Make, Get, Have Cause)

(i) I made my friend write a letter.

(ii) My friend was made to write a letter.

(iii) He got his house painted by expert painters.

(iv) He had a house demolished.

NOTE In sentence (i) the causative verb 'make' is followed by direct infinitive 'write'. In sentence (ii) 'make' is followed by 'to write' because it is in passive voice.

But we can say **'They caused him to leave India'**.

[Refer to Rule II (b) on Non-finite verbs.]

Rule XIII

When negative ideas are introduced in a noun clause with the following verbs in principal clause, it is advisable to make principal clause in negative.
‘imagine, think, believe, suppose’.

NOTE This rule doesn't apply to 'I hope'. For example

(i) I don't think he will pass.

(Correct)

I think he will not pass.

(Incorrect)

(ii) I don't suppose she will pass.

(Correct)

I suppose she will not pass.

(Incorrect)

Rule XIV

The position of verb in the clause beginning with ‘As’ and ‘Than’, when the subject is hidden. For example

(i) The guests came on time **as were hoped**.

[say, (it) was hoped]

(ii) The guests came more in number **than was expected**.

[say, (they) were expected]

(iii) There were more mangoes than were expected.

[say, (it) was expected]

(iv) There were more servants than was required.

[say, (they) were required]

Rule XV

Verbs Often Confused

The Base Form (Present)	Past	Past Participle (PP)
1. Swing	Swung	Swung
2. Wring	Wrung	Wrung
3. Sting	Stung	Stung
4. Find	Found	Found
5. Found	Founded	Founded
6. Fall	Fell	Fallen
7. Fell	Felled	Felled
8. Befall	Befell	Befallen
9. Fly	Flew	Flown
10. Blow	Blew	Blown
11. Flow	Flowed	Flowed
12. Strike	Struck	Struck
13. Stick	Stuck	Stuck
14. See	Saw	Seen
15. Saw	Sawed	Sawed/Sawn
16. Flee	Fled	Fled
17. Affect	Affected	Affected
18. Effect	Effected	Effected
19. Rend	Rent	Rent
20. Rent	Rented	Rented

The Base Form (Present)	Past	Past Participle (PP)
21. Awake	Awoke	Awoke/Awaken
22. Wake	Woke	Woken
23. Lie	Lied	Lied
24. Lie	Lay	Lain
25. Lay	Laid	Laid
26. Hang	Hanged	Hanged
27. Hang	Hung	Hung
28. Cast	Cast	Cast
29. Telecast	Telecast	Telecast
30. Forecast	Forecast	Forecast
31. Cost	Cost	Cost
32. Lose	Lost	Lost
33. Rise	Rose	Risen
34. Raise	Raised	Raised
35. Arise	Arose	Arisen
36. Rouse	Roused	Roused
37. Bind	Bound	Bound
38. Bound	Bounded	Bounded
39. Practise	Practised	Practised
40. Advise	Advised	Advised
41. Devise	Devised	Devised
42. Prophesy	Prophesied	Prophesied
43. Grind	Ground	Ground
44. Ground	Grounded	Grounded
45. Bear	Bore	Borne
46. Bear	Bore	Born
47. Wind	Wound	Wound
48. Wound	Wounded	Wounded
49. Forego	Forewent	Foregone
50. Forgo	Forwent	Forgone